

The Present

Times change and in a matter of four years, most phones are capable of capturing photos at a decent 640 x 480 resolution—good enough to be displayed on a phone screen and distributed electronically, at least. The display screen has also improved significantly and 65K colour screens are now the norm.

Storage problems that hampered early camera phones have also vanished thanks to the integration of higher built-in memory and the fact that most camera phones now support memory cards capable of storing gigabytes of data. With Bluetooth gaining popularity amongst these phones, exchanging these photos is no longer a painful process either. All in all, the picture is a rosy one!

The Future

The next imminent development around the corner is the introduction of 5-megapixel sensors in camera phones enabling you to take shots at much higher resolutions and rival a digital camera. Some pundits have even gone far enough to suggest that after killing the PDA prematurely, these devices may soon spell the end of the road for dedicated digital imaging devices. We're not so sure about that yet!

Chitkara Ambalika of Motorola agrees that the trend has caught up thanks to falling prices. "Camera phones were in their nascent stages till 2003 but have really caught up with the prices going down," she says. "With the whole mobile phone industry observing a downward trend in prices, it is likely that camera phones will follow these trends," she says discarding possibilities that the prices may fall further.

But the Indian market has emerged as one of the largest for these products. With growing penetration of cell phones, most companies are putting their best foot forward by intro-



The Megapixel Wars

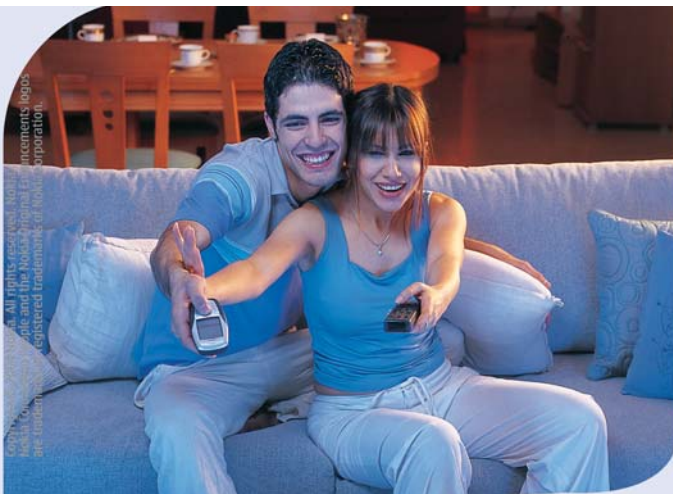
It all started with low resolution cameras in camera phones. But as is the case with the evolution of any device, cameras in these phones have become better with over the past year. Cameras in camera phones have in fact gained precedence over any other feature in the phone. One megapixel might well be the norm at the moment, but soon enough, the number will rise. Samsung has already announced a 5 megapixel phone but only for the Korean market. Manufacturers are also starting to bundle more capabilities such as Print Image Matching (PIM) to ensure quality of prints from the camera phone. While the rest of the world is witnessing an increasing number of 1-plus megapixel phones being launched, those available currently also include video shooting capabilities. Sony Ericsson has it, Nokia has it, Motorola has it, Samsung definitely has it... do you?

ducing the latest and the best along with the rest of the world. "Indian consumers are aware of the latest trends and benefits offered by the growth in technology. They are also looking at value for money," says Ambalika, summing up the market scenario.

Asian markets, mainly India and China, are driving the overall mobile phone market given the fact that the number of first-time buyers here is higher than elsewhere. In Europe, US and Japan, the other major markets, it's more or a replacement or an upgradation market.

In the US, for example, camera phone penetration has reached 14 per cent of the total cell phone user base in just four years. In 2004, according to an In-Stat/MDR study, camera phone shipments around the world went up by 200 per cent.

According to the latest APRG demand data, camera phones will grow over 50 per cent on a compound annual (CAGR) basis through 2007. This, coupled with other options such as mobile gaming (which generated almost \$26 million in 2004 in India), makes this a hot market to be in. Nokia, in



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